

ASSUMPTIONS AND NATURE OF ARTS: CREATIVITY, IMAGINATION

Art History and art appreciation are distinct fields in understanding art. **Art history** focuses on the chronological development of art forms, styles, and artists, analyzing their significance and impact on historical narratives. It uses research, analysis, and interpretation to understand how art shapes human societies and ideologies. On the other hand, **art appreciation** emphasizes the subjective experience and personal interpretation of artworks that encourage viewers to engage with and derive meaning from them through aesthetic appreciation and emotional response.

Basic Assumptions of Arts

Many assumptions have been made about art, including the following:

1. **Art is universal**

- It communicates emotions and ideas that resonate across cultures.
- It reflects universal human experiences like love and struggle.
- It inspires and remains relevant across generations.
- It offers diverse interpretations to deepen its meaning.

2. **Art is cultural**

- It reflects society's beliefs, values, and traditions.
- Historical events and social norms influence it.
- It means different cultures produce unique art forms with distinct styles and symbols.
- It requires an understanding of the cultural context for interpretation.

3. **Art involves experience**

- It engages artists and viewers emotionally and personally.
- It stimulates the senses through what we see, hear, or touch.
- It allows the exploration and expression of emotions, ideas, and perspectives.
- It shapes perceptions and responses to surroundings through active participation and interpretation.

Visual Art

Visual Art uses **colors, shapes, lines, and textures** to evoke ideas, emotions, and experiences to reshape how we see the world through creative expression. Below are some examples of 2D and 3D Visual art forms.

2D Visual Arts

Two-dimensional (2D) art has only the dimensions of **height** and **width**. It occurs on flat surfaces like paper or canvas. Below are some forms of 2D Visual Arts.

1. **Painting** – It uses pigments on surfaces like canvas or paper to portray scenes, emotions, or concepts.
2. **Drawing** – It creates images with pencils, pens, charcoal, and other tools on paper or surfaces from realistic to abstract styles.
3. **Printmaking** – It uses techniques like etching, woodcut, or screen printing to reproduce artwork.

3D Visual Arts

Three-dimensional (3D) art uses **height**, **width**, and **depth** to create tangible artworks. Below are some forms of 3D Visual Arts.

1. **Sculpture** – It transforms materials like stone, metal, wood, or clay into intricate figures.
2. **Architecture** – It involves designing and constructing buildings and structures.
3. **Installation Art** – It refers to large-scale artworks designed for specific spaces, incorporating diverse materials.

Functions of Art and Philosophy

The function of art says a lot about its state, purpose, and style, including the following:

1. **Physical Function** – It provides **tangible value**.

Example: A chair designed by an artist that not only serves as seating but also incorporates artistic elements in its form and design.

2. **Social Function** – It addresses **public issues and perspectives**.

Example: A mural painted in a public space that depicts historical events or celebrates cultural diversity, fostering community pride and dialogue.

3. **Personal Function** – It offers **subjective self-expression** and introspection.

Example: A self-portrait painted by an artist, which serves as a means of self-expression, introspection, and conveying personal emotions or identity.

Basic Philosophical Perspectives

Basic philosophical perspectives in art are foundational frameworks that influence how artists and viewers perceive, create, and interpret artistic expression.

1. **Art as Imitation** – Plato viewed art as imitation because it **represents imperfect copies of ideal forms from the World of Forms**. He believed art distracts from pursuing true knowledge and virtue by appealing to emotions rather than reason. Plato suggested restricting or even excluding art to prevent it from distorting people's understanding of reality.

Example: Plato viewed that a painting of a tree would be considered an imitation of the physical tree, which itself is an imperfect copy of the ideal Form of "Tree" in the World of Forms.

2. **Art as Representation** – Aristotle agreed with Plato that art imitates, but he saw it as a way for philosophy to uncover truths. He believed art shows **different realities** and **explores various possibilities**. Aristotle said art serves two main purposes: it **gives pleasure** by turning hardships into humor and **teaches important lessons about life and its complexities**.

Example: Aristotle viewed tragedy, such as Sophocles' "Oedipus Rex," as a portrayal of human actions, emotions, and moral dilemmas that reflect the intricate nature of fate and human experience.

3. **Art as Disinterested Judgment** – Kant's idea of **assessing beauty** in artworks involves an **objective approach**, distinct from personal preferences. It requires viewers to contemplate art with

detachment, focusing on its **universal aesthetic qualities** rather than individual emotions or subjective tastes.

Example: When someone says, “I like this painting,” it indicates a subjective judgment based on personal preferences and emotions. In contrast, when someone says, “This painting is beautiful,” it reflects an aesthetic judgment. According to Kant, aesthetic judgments require a disinterested contemplation of the artwork, focusing on its universal beauty rather than personal feelings.

4. **Art as Communication of Emotion** – Leo Tolstoy believed that art **communicates emotions from the artist to the audience, similar to how language conveys information**. He viewed art as a means to **unite people by sharing inner thoughts and feelings**, making emotions central to human existence.

Example: Tolstoy’s own novels, “War and Peace” and “Anna Karenina,” convey complex human feelings such as love, despair, and hope through their character and narratives.

Subject and Content

Subject types refer to what the artist portrays, such as people, objects, scenes, or events. There are two main subject types:

- **Representational art** realistically depicts **recognizable objects, scenes, or figures** to convey ideas and emotions, adapting to cultural changes.
Examples: Portraits, Landscapes, Still Life, etc.
- **Non-representational art** uses shapes, colors, forms, and textures to evoke emotions or ideas **without recognizable objects**. It focuses on **artistic expression** rather than depicting specific subjects.
Examples: Abstract Expressionism, Surrealism, Minimalism, etc.

Source of Subject

Sources of Subject refer to the diverse **inspirations** and **themes** artists draw from, including the following:

1. **Personal Experiences** – It depicts **emotions, memories, and life events from the artist’s perspective**.
Example: Frida Kahlo’s Self Portraits

2. **Nature** – It captures **natural landscapes, elements, and organisms**, reflecting the beauty and rhythms of the natural world.
Example: “Flowers Of the Field” by Ernest Walbourn

3. **History** – It represents events, periods, or themes, aiming to document, interpret, or critique events, offering insights into **past societies** and their **impact on the present**.
Example: “The Death of Marat” by David

Content in Art

Content in Art refers to the ideas, emotions, and narratives depicted in artworks. Artists use various techniques to communicate their content, shaping its impact on viewers.

Levels of Meaning

Levels of Meaning refer to the various layers of interpretation beyond its surface appearance.

1. **Literal** – It refers to the **straightforward depiction** or narrative content.

Example: A painting of a bowl of fruit is literally about fruit.

2. **Symbolic** – It uses **symbols** to represent **deeper abstract ideas** or **concepts**.

Example: A red rose often symbolizes love or passion across different cultures.

3. **Personal** – It is the **viewer's personal experiences**, beliefs, and emotions that significantly influence their understanding and connection with the artwork.

Example: A contemporary abstract painting may evoke different interpretations based on individual experiences that allow viewers to find personal meaning in its colors and forms.

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